Call for Proposals

Development of the Better Work Smart Toolbox: An AI-powered system for managing and customizing training and advisory tools.

The Better Work Programme

Better Work, a partnership between the International Labour Organization (ILO) and the International Finance Corporation (IFC), aims to improve working conditions and enhance business competitiveness in the global garment industry. Active since 2003, the programme now operates in around 2,000 factories employing more than 3 million workers across the globe.

Through its core services—factory assessments, advisory support, and training—Better Work helps enterprises comply with labour standards, strengthens national institutions, and supports social dialogue among employers, workers, and governments. The programme also works closely with global brands to ensure that improvements are sustained and aligned with broader development goals. Better Work's vision is a global garment industry that promotes decent work, empowers women, drives competitiveness, and contributes to inclusive economic growth.

Background

Managing the wide range of training, advisory, and intervention tools developed across Better Work's global and country operations has become increasingly challenging. At the Global Secretariat level, the lack of a centralized, standardized, and searchable repository makes it difficult to track updates, avoid duplication, and ensure consistent methodologies across 13 country programmes. Country teams face parallel challenges in navigating available materials, identifying what is most relevant for their needs, adapting content efficiently, and learning from good practices developed elsewhere.

The absence of an integrated, intelligent knowledge management system is therefore a key barrier to harmonized approaches, efficient content design, and consistent service delivery.

Objectives

Better Work seeks for an external provider to support the development of a smart digital toolbox which:

a) serves as a repository and archive of Better Work's body of knowledge and resources for training and advisory work in the context of garment manufacturing;
b) facilitates intelligent search, filtering, and selection of the most relevant tools and materials based on user needs;
c) supports the assembly of tailored solutions—across topic areas and content formats—using generative AI techniques such as retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) or fine-tuning of existing enterprise-grade models;
d) enables future interoperability with Better Work's existing data environment in a manner that may eventually allow AI-supported recommendations informed by factory assessment and monitoring data.

This will ideally be achieved through the use of generative AI, towards enhancing how users access, understand, and combine Better Work materials. This may include:

- Analyzing and categorizing knowledge assets and, where appropriate, breaking them into smaller reusable modules through automated tagging and classification;
- Sifting through all resources to provide the most relevant options in response to a user's query, based on content, context, and user intent;
- Assisting users in refining their search, clarifying their needs and selecting resources through interactive prompts and guided questioning
- Selecting and combining tools and resources into coherent solutions (e.g. exercises from different session plans based on learning objectives)
- Tailoring/adapting existing instructional material to accompany these results (e.g. facilitator's guideline / session flow / workshop schedule etc.)

In a second stage of development, behavioral insights will be applied in the development of user interface and design, to ensure that the Toolbox is built around real user needs, habits, and constraints. The strength of the Toolbox lies in the **combination** of behavioural design and generative AI, the former ensuring that the platform meets real user needs and nudges effective use, and the latter enabling rapid, intelligent access to the right content at the right time. Together, they will enable Better Work staff to design, adapt, and deliver interventions more efficiently, consistently, and at scale. Even though the behavioral design component is not included in the present terms, the service provider will need to take into account that it will be plugged in later during development.

▶ Target users

The first and primary users of the Toolbox are Better Work staff across 10 country programmes (ca 200 staff), with the following profiles:

- Enterprise Advisors, who conduct factory assessments and provide advisory and coaching sessions to address identified compliance gaps.
- Trainers, who design and deliver capacity-building programmes drawn from Better Work's training catalogue.
- Technical Focal Points and Non–Factory-Facing Staff, who provide thematic expertise (e.g., gender, industrial relations, OSH, management systems) and deliver adapted training or advisory support to government partners, unions, industry associations, buyers, and other stakeholders.

The alpha version will focus on these internal users and remain a closed-source platform. Over time, the Toolbox may be expanded to serve:

- external actors who perform similar functions (e.g., brand representatives, MSIs, NGOs, private sector service providers);
- professionals in other industries with comparable advisory or training roles;
- ILO staff beyond the Better Work Programme.

The platform should therefore be designed with future scalability, role diversity, and multi-stakeholder usability in mind.

▶ Scope

The Toolbox will host and structure a wide range of Better Work training and advisory resources. In addition to digitizing and organizing these materials, the platform should integrate AI-powered functions for:

- intelligent search and resource retrieval;
- modularization and tagging of content;
- automated or semi-automated assembly of session plans, toolkits, and intervention packages;
- optional adaptation of templates or guidance materials using secure, enterprise LLMs;
- support for future scenarios in which Toolbox recommendations may interface with Better Work's data management system (e.g., recommending training based on compliance data once governance and technical conditions allow).

In this first stage, the language of the platform as well as of resources hosted and produced on it will be English. However, the platform must be designed so that **multi-language capability, interoperability, and scalability** can be added in future phases.

Development could foresee a pilot phase involving limited resources and geographical scope.

▶ The toolbox within the broader Better Work and ILO ecosystem

As Better Work moves toward a more integrated, data-driven, and scalable operational model, the Smart Toolbox may become a cornerstone for harmonizing training, advisory tools, and approaches across countries and with external partners. Close alignment with the ongoing evolution of Better Work's operations and business model – and with ILO-wide efforts to build unified, interoperable infrastructures – is essential. The following three dimensions should be kept in mind.

Scaling impact and strengthening sustainability

As part of its current strategy—and increasingly in the next strategic cycle beginning in 2028—Better Work aims to scale its impact by expanding beyond tier-1 garment suppliers, enabling implementation through partners, and extending support to additional sectors. The Smart Toolbox can play a critical role in this transition by streamlining knowledge management, standardizing methodologies, and simplifying the customization of training and advisory tools for different contexts.

Training-of-trainers and the transfer of Better Work methodologies will become even more central to the Programme's sustainability model. The Toolbox should therefore be designed to support these scale pathways by making it easier for partners and intermediaries to access, understand, and adapt Better Work content. Its development must also be coordinated closely with the ongoing review of the Better Work Academy to ensure that both initiatives reinforce each other, avoid duplication, and contribute to a coherent long-term capacity-building architecture.

AI-assisted information and data management

Through its yearly assessment, advisory and training cycles in 2,000+ factories, Better Work gathers, processes, and manages a large volume of structured and unstructured data through its custom-built data system. Since 2024, the Programme has begun exploring the application of AI and machine learning—particularly generative AI—for tasks such as assisted report writing, qualitative data analysis, and pattern identification.

In future iterations, the Smart Toolbox may be integrated within this broader data and information ecosystem. This could allow the platform to draw on insights generated from factory assessments and advisory records to offer more tailored and data-driven recommendations (e.g., suggesting training or advisory resources linked to specific compliance challenges). This aligns with ongoing developments in ASTRA, where training courses are being mapped to clusters and compliance points; AI-supported matching could further improve the recommendation process for enterprise advisors, trainers, and factories.

At this stage, the expectation is not to build a proprietary AI model from scratch. Instead, the contractor may leverage existing, secure large language model frameworks (e.g., Microsoft Copilot Studio or equivalent enterprise-grade models) through fine-tuning, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), or similar techniques within a closed, compliant environment where Better Work data remain protected and are not used to train public models. Any such integration must be carried out in alignment with ILO data protection, security regulations, and with the necessary internal approvals.

One-ILO delivery

Better Work is committed to strengthening its integration within the broader ILO programme ecosystem and to fostering joint delivery models across projects focused on supply chains, enterprise development, skills, and sectoral approaches. Experiences from Egypt, Ethiopia, and other contexts demonstrate that multi-programme collaboration—supported by shared methodologies, harmonized tools, and aligned monitoring frameworks—can significantly amplify impact at workplace, sector, and national levels.

The Smart Toolbox has the potential to become a shared infrastructure that supports this type of collaboration. By organizing, structuring, and standardizing Better Work's resources in an interoperable format, the Toolbox can facilitate alignment with other ILO initiatives and, over time, could evolve into a common digital asset for the Organization. Its design should therefore anticipate future usability across programmes, ensure compatibility with ILO standards, and encourage reusability by teams working in related thematic or sectoral areas.

▶ Description of assignment

The selected service provider will design, develop, test, and support initial deployment of the Better Work Smart Toolbox. This includes:

- conducting user research and content workflow analysis;
- designing a platform architecture that integrates secure generative AI features using existing enterprise-grade LLMs rather than creating proprietary models;
- implementing AI-assisted functions such as tagging, intelligent search, content recommendation, and modularized content assembly using approved techniques such as RAG or fine-tuning;
- ensuring all AI components operate within a secure, closed environment in line with ILO data governance requirements and subject to INFOTECH approval;
- preparing the system for potential future integration with BW own or other ILO data systems.

The contractor will work in close collaboration with Better Work's Global Secretariat, selected country programme representatives and the International Training Centre of the ILO. The assignment includes user research, design workshops, iterative prototyping, AI tool integration, pilot deployment, and capacity-building components.

The deliverables should demonstrate clear alignment with Better Work's strategic direction as outlined in this document and under the guidance of the Project Working group, by enabling shared use of tools, minimizing duplication, and facilitating integration with broader ILO operational frameworks.

Required skills and qualifications

The multidisciplinary team or firm must bring:

- demonstrated experience using enterprise-grade generative AI tools (e.g., Microsoft Azure OpenAI, Copilot Studio, or equivalent) within secure, closed environments;
- expertise in retrieval-augmented generation, fine-tuning, or similar approaches for domain-specific customization of LLMs;
- strong capacities in data governance, security compliance, and responsible AI use in institutional environments;
- experience integrating digital learning or knowledge management platforms with existing organizational systems;
- UX/UI, human-centered design, and behavioral insights expertise for training and capacity-building contexts will be considered an asset;
- Experience working with or within multilateral organizations, especially UN or ILO, and an understanding of global development, supply chains, or training for compliance in manufacturing settings is a strong advantage.

Tasks and deliverables

Deliverable	Tasks	Outputs	Timeline
Discovery & Design (20%)	▪ Analyse and map content types and content workflows; ▪ Develop methodology for behavioral and needs analysis; ▪ Conduct user research with Better Work staff in selected country programmes.	▪ Methodological proposal, ▪ Needs analysis report, ▪ wireframes, user personas and proposed information structure;	July - August 2026
Prototype Development (30%)	▪ Build a functional prototype of the toolbox. ▪ Integrate AI features such as content tagging, intelligent search, and content recommendation. ▪ Conduct usability testing with staff.	▪ Functional alpha version of toolbox; ▪ prototype test report.	Sept - Oct 2026
Pilot and Iteration (25%)	▪ Pilot platform in 1–2 country programmes. ▪ Refine based on feedback, including performance, usability, and content integration.	▪ Updated beta version; pilot evaluation report.	Nov 2026 – Jan 2027
Deployment and Knowledge Transfer (25%)	▪ Support initial deployment of toolbox. ▪ Develop user manuals and training resources. ▪ Conduct capacity-building sessions for Better Work and ILO staff.	▪ Final platform (v1.0), ▪ Documentation and training resources	Feb - Mar 2027

Cross-cutting tasks

- Ensure alignment with existing ILO frameworks and standards (including security, data protection and governance, ethics).
- Coordinate with teams currently working on the Better Work Academy and other relevant ILO platforms to ensure coherence and reusability.
- Document learnings to inform future development phases

Gender-responsiveness and inclusiveness

The service provider is expected to apply a strong gender lens throughout the assignment, ensuring that both the platform and its AI-enabled functions actively promote gender equality, avoid reinforcing bias, and remain accessible to diverse users across gender identities and backgrounds. This includes:

- **Applying gender-responsive, inclusive design principles** in all stages of the platform's development—ensuring that navigation, workflows, language, images, and user journeys are intuitive and equitable for female, male, and non-binary users, and that no aspect of the interface creates avoidable barriers for any group.

- **Ensuring that AI-driven features are gender-fair and bias-mitigated**, including testing the underlying search, tagging, and recommendation functions for unintended gendered patterns, stereotypes, or skewed suggestions. Providers must outline how they will detect, monitor, and correct gender bias in AI outputs.

- **Embedding gender-transformative search and recommendation logic,** enabling the identification, retrieval, and prioritization of materials that advance gender equality and non-discrimination, and using behavioral prompts or nudges to encourage uptake of such content when relevant.

- **Using inclusive and non-stereotypical language** throughout the platform—including system prompts, instructions, and templates—consistently applying gender-neutral phrasing and avoiding assumptions about roles, capacities, or identities.

- **Ensuring that visuals, examples, and mockups reflect diversity** in gender, body type, complexion, ability, and cultural background, and that portrayals break rather than reproduce gender stereotypes.

- **Supporting gender-responsive content migration and metadata practices,** including tagging materials that explicitly address gender-related issues (e.g., GBVH prevention, equal opportunity, inclusive leadership), and ensuring that such content is easily discoverable through the platform's search or recommendation engine.

- **Applying gender-responsive methods in user research and feedback collection**, ensuring that women and other underrepresented groups are adequately included and that their perspectives shape the iterative development process.

This approach ensures that the Smart Toolbox not only avoids reinforcing gender bias but also proactively contributes to Better Work's broader commitment to gender equality, inclusion, and fair treatment across workplaces and supply chains.

Reporting

The consultant will report to Francesca Biasiato, Technical Officer on Gender Equality, Non-discrimination and Inclusion.

The Smart Toolbox will be developed in close collaboration with the International Training Centre of the ILO (ITC-ILO. A working group across Better Work, ILO technical departments and ITC-ILO will be put together to ensure technical oversight across disciplines – Better Work operations and systems, knowledge and data management, behavioural science, learning technology and innovation.

Copyright and confidentiality

The materials produced by the contractor during the period of contract shall be the exclusive property of the ILO and shall not be re-produced, distributed, or utilized without the expressed, written permission of the ILO.

All data and information received for the purpose of this assignment are to be treated confidentially and are only to be used in connection with the execution of these Terms of Reference. All intellectual property rights arising from the execution of these Terms of Reference are assigned to IFC and ILO. The contents of written materials obtained and used in this assignment may not be disclosed to any third parties without the express advance written authorization of the IFC and ILO.

How to apply

Interested candidates wishing to apply to this assignment must send an email to BETTERWORK@ilo.org with the subject "BW Smart Toolbox":

The email shall include:

- A technical proposal, including proposed methodology, a workplan based on the information provided in this document and inclusive of a schedule of activities, evidence of past relevant experiences, CV(s);

- A financial proposal, including rates (in USD) and breakdown of allocations (the assignment is to be carried out remotely and no extra budget should be necessary for mission travel).

The deadline for receiving applications is **May 22nd, 2026**.

Only short-listed applicants will be contacted.